



the Dinka live in villages built on sandbanks emerging out of the swamps and cultivate crops. However, in the dry season, which runs from September to May, all able-bodied Dinka leave the village in search of pasture

and water for their animals. Since 1983, southern Sudan has been blighted by civil war. Many people have been killed and vast numbers of cattle have died, gotten lost, or been abandoned in the course of the fighting.

MILK AND BUTTER

Women and children are responsible for milking the cattle and distributing dairy products. The milk is collected in gourds. Some of it is drunk right away, some is soured for storing, and if there is any extra, some is churned to make butter.



A USE FOR EVERYTHING

Of course, milk and butter are valuable as food, but the Dinka find a way to use everything that the cattle produce. Cow urine, which is sterile and antiseptic, is collected and used for cleaning wounds, washing, and tanning hides. The ash from burned cow dung has many uses too, including insect repellent (see below), makeup, and toothpaste! Although cows are not generally slaughtered, when an animal dies its hide is used to make mats, drums, belts, and ropes. Nothing is wasted, not even horns and bones.

A NATURAL INSECT REPELLENT

Keeping flies and mosquitoes at bay is a priority in the cattle camp. Not only do they irritate both people and animals, but they are also capable of spreading diseases.



1 Dung repellent

A young girl collects cow dung at the Wunbel cattle camp in southern Sudan. There is plenty of it available for use as a natural insect repellent.



2 Bonfires

At dusk the dung is burned. People and animals gather around the fires fueled by burning dung. The smoke covers everything and keeps insects away.



3 Using the ash

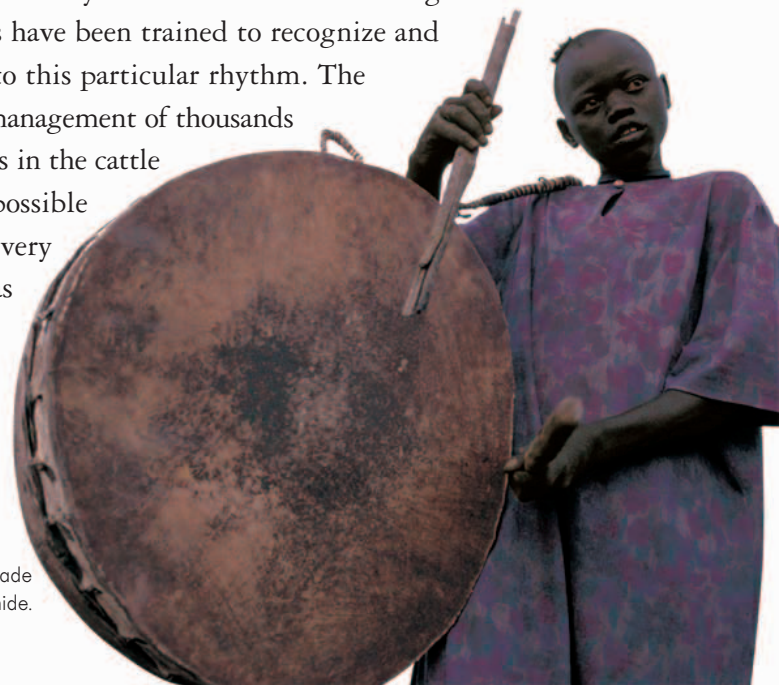
The Dinka cover themselves with the insect-repelling ash. With typical Dinka concern for their animals, they also rub the ash into the skin of their cows.

Calling the cattle

A Dinka child beats his drum to a specific rhythm to call his family's cows to his *khat*, a specific area in the middle of the camp where they will be tethered for the night.

The cows have been trained to recognize and respond to this particular rhythm. The smooth management of thousands of animals in the cattle camp is possible

because every family has its own rhythm.



Large drum made out of cow hide.